telligence HQ in Mohali and the murder of a kabaddi player in Jalandhar.

The opposition blames much of all this on AAP leaders soft-peddling the radical Sikh agenda. They cite the pro-Khalistan march in Amritsar on June 6 and the July 11 decision of state agency Pepsu Road Transport Corporation (PRTC) to withdraw orders asking for the removals of posters glorifying terrorists like Jagtar Singh Hawara and the late Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale after protests by Sikh hardliners.

As a corrective measure, the Mann regime brought in new people to head the police force and the civil administration. But that too has run into rough weather. State DGP V.K. Bhawra proceeded on leave after seeking central deputation. Gaurav Yadav, a 1992 batch IPS officer perceived to be close to Kejriwal, was picked to officiate in his absence (ignoring the seniority of at least five other IPS officers). More controversial was the appointment of Vijay Kumar Janjua as chief secretary. Janjua is facing corruption charges and has been arrested in the past by the state vigilance bureau. "On the one hand you want to project yourself as an anti-corruption crusader, but then you have a chief secretary with corruption charges hanging over him. This can't be part of the same play," says the Congress's Bajwa. The AAP government and Mann need to pull up their socks, and soon. They have little leeway for the next big test—elections for the urban bodies—is expected at the end of the year. ■

Observers say the Sangrur poll loss led to course corrections which have not paid off for the Mann government

MADHYA PRADESH

A SEMI WIN IN A SEMI FINAL

By Rahul Noronha



RESURGENT? MP Congress chief Kamal Nath's roadshow in Bhopal, July 4

ANI

The media and party leaders dubbed it the 'semi-finals' before the 2023 assembly poll in Madhya Pradesh, and the results of elections to 413 municipal bodies—held after a delay of two and a half years—justified the pre-bout hype. Presidents of the 99 municipalities and 298 nagar parishads will be elected later by councillors through indirect elections, but even if just the direct elections held for choosing mayors of 16 municipal corporations were to be considered, the results held enough scope for endless analysis—and introspection, for both the BJP and the Congress.

All 16 mayoral contests had been won by the BJP in 2015. This time, the saffron party managed to retain only nine, and the Congress took its tally from zero to 5. The BJP's defeat in Gwalior, Morena and Jabalpur was especially embarrassing. The Congress has won Gwalior after a gap of 57 years, and that it comes after the exit of the local big gun—Union minister Jyotiraditya Scindia—must gladden it. Narendra Singh Tomar, another Union minister, also hails from Gwalior region, as do other BJP biggies. The Congress also won Chhindwara, PCC president Kamal Nath's home turf, after a long time, and Rewa, headquarters of the Vindhya region where the Congress had been decimated in the 2018 assembly election. The grand old party nearly won Burhanpur and Ujjain too, losing to the BJP by less than 1,000 votes.

The BJP can take solace in the fact that it has a majority among councillors in most municipal corporations and